compensated for by the expansion of oaks and hickories. For Holling, this counted as resilience, because although the exact mix of tree species had changed, broad-leaved forest still remained.

Ecologists now understand that ecosystems can have more than one stable state. In Australia, for example, woodlands dominated by mulga trees can exist in a grass-rich environment that supports sheep-farming, or in a shrub-dominated environment that is totally unsuitable for sheep.

“Ecosystems are dynamic—constantly changing and inherently uncertain, with potential multiple futures …”

Crawford Stanley Holling